

Deepika Padukone, Ranveer Singh announce birth of baby girl



ENTERTAINMENT

HINDUSTAN TIMES

Actor Deepika Padukone got married to Ranveer Singh in a picturesque ceremony at Lake Como, Italy in 2018. It is their first baby together. Deepika Padukone and Ranveer Singh have officially confirmed that they became parents on Sunday.

JULY’S UNTOLD HEROES

THE SONG OF HIJRA COMMUNITY

COMMUNITY

MIRAZ HOSSAIN

During the July movement, the Hijra community stepped up with physical labor, blood donation, and monetary contribution. They did everything they could out of humanity

“Have you ever carried an almost dead person who may die in your arms?” Priya, a prominent member of the Hijra community, asked before we even started the interview, as if those horrific memories still haunted her. “It’s such a helpless and burdensome feeling, which I can’t put into words,” she said.

On July 15 evening, as the Dhaka University campus simmered in tension and violence, Priya, the second in command of the Shahabag area’s Hijra community, was watching a Facebook video of Chhatra League men beating the students, even girls! Priya was at her residence on Najimuddin Road, where she lived with her other group members.

“I told my Guru Ma (the leader of the Hijra community), ‘We survive on what we collect from Dhaka University students. If they’re in danger, so are we. We have to stand by them,’” said Priya, explaining how they got involved. Her leader, Mukta, asked what she wanted to do, and she said, “As many of us as possible will volunteer at DMCH.”

Answering the Call of Humanity

Thus, a remarkable act of solidarity came from one of the “most disadvantaged populations in Asian-Pacific countries,” according to a 2022 study published in Heliyon.

Priya gathered her team, including Habiba, Nodi, Boishakhi, Mugdho and their elderly leader, who, at 75, refused to stay home. From July 16 to 25, the Hijra community became an indomitable force in a time of need.

When they started working in the emergency department on July 16, the authorities did not like it. They even threatened them, saying, “Police cases will be filed against you.” But the Hijras explained that they had come out of their own will, and they began by holding stretchers and carrying the wounded.

But little did they know that the worst days were ahead. “The horror began on July 17. Scores of people came in with gunshot wounds. It wasn’t just men; women and children were among them, too,” recalled Priya, her eyes distant.

The scene at DMCH was terrible. Injured and dead people arrived in a constant stream—rickshaws, vans, CNGs, ambulances, and mini-trucks bringing in victims. Most were shot—some in the hands, legs, chest, throat, or head—often with bodies riddled with bullets. Vehicles, at times, were packed with patients.

But the hospital was woefully understaffed. The few staff present largely shirked their duties. That’s where Priya and her group stepped in. They lend hands to unload bodies, place them on stretchers, arrange medicine and blood, or move them to the morgue. “We had to



Priya (right) and Nodi (left) are two of the Hijra community members who provided much-needed voluntary services during the July atrocities and the August flood. PHOTO: MIRAZ HOSSAIN/ THE DAILY MIRROR

help,” said another Hijra, Nodi, her voice filled with the weight of those chaotic days. “People were dying.”

A Lifeline of Blood

When the Hijra community heard that the hospital was running out of blood, they went beyond physical labor. They organized a blood donation campaign. With their effort, 36 Hijras donated blood themselves, and within two days, they had collected 730 bags of blood—no small feat in a city paralyzed by fear.

Priya recounted how they stood with placards outside the hospital, urging the public to donate blood. “We asked everyone to give blood,” she said. We didn’t care where it came from; we just wanted to help.”

The community also raised 3 lakh taka in cash donations during this time. That money went toward buying medicine, arranging ambulances, and covering the costs of sending dead bodies back to their families. “We even bought silicon bags for blood when DMCH couldn’t provide them,” Priya explained. “And for those who donated blood, we gave them water and juice.”

The Gravity of the Atrocities

Priya and her team witnessed the atrocities firsthand: bullet wounds that spread inside the body, explosions that left victims unrecognizable, and a constant stream of ambulances delivering more people than the hospital could handle. Priya recalls an instance where a boy’s

body was brought in on a rickshaw, half of his head blown off. Many of the injured arrived with slim chances of survival. “Most people didn’t make it,” Priya said quietly, her voice reflecting the pain of those days. “The doctors said the bullets had hit vital organs. It wasn’t just hands or legs.”

She and her community worked from morning until night, often staying at the hospital until 4 or 5 a.m. before returning by 11. “We couldn’t rest,” she said. “There were too many people who needed us.”

Confronting Exploitation

As if the situation wasn’t dire enough, the Hijra community also had to fight exploitation from an ambulance syndicate that began charging higher prices. Priya was appalled. “How could they do that?” she asked, still incredulous. “We knew some people who ran ambulances, and we called them in to help. But when we ran out of options, we had no choice but to pay the higher prices.”

On July 18, a schoolboy was shot. His father, a rickshaw driver from Jhenaidah, couldn’t afford to take his son’s body home. The boy was hit by two bullets. One nestled in his chest, and the other pierced through his body. He died on the spot. “His father was devastated,” Priya said. “He had no money to take his son home, and it was getting late at night. We arranged an ambulance and paid 10,000 taka to make sure he could take his son home.”

The Weight of Tragedy

The carnage they witnessed and the memories of it still haunt them. “We carried them [patients] with our own hands. Whoever we took inside, they were gone within 10 or 15 minutes,” Priya remembered, her voice shaking slightly.

One of the most haunting moments for Priya was when she discovered the body of Rifat, a 22-year-old who had been helping them from time to time since the 17th of July. He was shot and killed on August 5. “He wanted to join the long march, but he ended up in a coffin instead. His family didn’t even know he had died. There’s nothing more painful than that,” Priya recalled, taking a pause.

“Those days, our bodies were drenched in blood. Even there were days when the smell of blood made it impossible to eat,” she added.

They could not even celebrate the news that Hasina fled. “Even on the evening of August 5, bodies were still coming in,” she remembered.

Priya believes that the injured individuals and the families of those who died during those harrowing days deserve government support. “Just like freedom fighters receive pensions, the families of these martyrs should receive support,” she said. “They sacrificed their lives for the country. Their families need help.”

The Community in the Flood Crisis

The Hijra community’s involvement didn’t end with the movement. Just when the dust of July settled, there was a massive flood in the Feni area. “They continued to provide support during the floods. They volunteered when we made packets of relief at TSC; they even donated money,” said Faisal Ahmed, one of the key Coordinators of the Student Against Discrimination movement.

They even sent a team to Feni to help the flood-affected people and to provide them with relief. “We worked throughout the entire relief effort,” Priya said proudly. Thirty of us worked.”

A Marginalized Group Finds Purpose

The Hijra community, according to a study by Bipul Kumar Sarker in 2020, “one of the most violated and marginalized minority groups in Bangladesh,” found a new sense of purpose in the crisis. “We don’t have much,” Priya said, “but we save what we can. We always try to step up in times of need.” She recalled how, during the Bongobazar fire, they donated 23 lakh taka to help the victims. Now, during the floods in Feni, they contributed another 7 lakh.

“People didn’t ask how we survived when there was no income from June to August,” Priya said. “But we save small amounts for times like this. And when the crisis comes, we help however we can.”

Again, back to the horror of July, “We were there from the beginning to the very end,” Priya said, her voice filled with quiet pride. “We don’t want to show off. We just did what we had to do,” adding, “If needed, we would do it again.”

The contribution of the Hijra community is a reminder for us to come forward for others—no matter who we are or whom we are for. This ostracized community showed the nation what it means to be truly human, and they deserve more respect in society.



‘Toofan’ to release on OTT platforms on 19 September

FILM

TDM REPORT

Shakib Khan-starrer “Toofan” is set to stream on OTT platforms Chorki and Hoichoi on 19 September.

The streaming platform Chorki announced the news from their Facebook page and said, “The highly anticipated “Toofan” is coming to the local platform Chorki, making waves worldwide! The wait will finally end on September 19!”

“Toofan” premiered in theatres earlier this year on 27 June.

Directed by Raihan Rafi, the film has a star-studded cast including Shakib Khan, Chanchal Chowdhury, Nabila, Mimi Chakraborty, Gazi Rakayet, and Fazlur Rahman Babu, among others.

It was informed to the media that the artist went to Delhi, India for treatment a few days ago. After being treated for prostate cancer from there, he returned home and was healthy.

One of Bangladesh’s pioneering and respected artists, Mustafa Monwar is also revered as the revolutionary behind promoting puppetry and television drama in the country.

His popular television puppet show ‘Moner Kotha’ ran on BTV for 12 years, which became immensely popular and remembered to date by the 90’s kids as one of BTV’s all-time classic programs, dedicated to children.

The Ekushey Padak-winning artist started his career as a lecturer at the East Pakistan College of Arts and Crafts.

Later, he joined as the Director General of the East Pakistan branch of PTV (now Bangladesh Television).

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Artist Mustafa Monwar on life support

SPLASH

UNB

Legendary Bangladeshi painter, sculptor and cultural personality Mustafa Monwar, lovingly known as Bangladesh’s ‘Puppet Man’, has been put on life support in a private hospital in the capital.

According to family sources of the artist, he has been suffering from various physical problems for a long time, most notably from pneumonia and prostate cancer.

On Saturday when his physical condition worsened, he was put on life support at Square Hospital.



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Ronaldo reaches 1 billion followers on social media



SPORTS

TDM REPORT

Cristiano Ronaldo has made history as the first individual to surpass 1 billion followers across social media platforms.

His massive following includes over 636 million on Instagram, 170 million on Facebook, and 112.5 million on X (formerly Twitter), cementing his status as one of the most influential figures globally.

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Beyond football, Ronaldo has leveraged his social media to share insights into his personal life, fitness routines, and projects, further connecting with fans. His recent YouTube channel launch, which attracted over a million subscribers in just 90 minutes, highlights his broad appeal.

Ronaldo’s global reach also extends to charitable efforts, using his platform to support social causes. As he continues to excel with Al-Nassr in Saudi Arabia, this achievement underscores his role not only as a football legend but also as a cultural icon with unmatched influence.

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Bangladesh women’s ‘A’ team open T20 series with dominant win

SPORTS

TDM REPORT

Veteran wicketkeeper-batter Shamima Sultana then played a crucial role in the run chase, with valuable contributions from Sathi Rani and Sobhana Mostary, helping the visitors chase down the 113-run target with seven balls to spare.

Despite a solid start from Sri Lanka’s openers, Kaushini Nuthyangana and Netmi Purna, who added 70 runs for the first wicket, Bangladesh’s bowlers kept the run rate under control.

Although this is an ‘A’ team series, the Bangladesh Cricket Board (BCB) has fielded several national team players, with the upcoming T20 World Cup in mind. The Bangladesh side had already secured the 50-over series and continued their strong form with today’s victory.

Bangladesh had rested key players Dilara Akter and Nigar Sultana, both of whom starred in the final 50-over match. Shamima, returning from illness after a long absence from the national team, made the most of her opportunity.

